function as a *madrasa* has long been accepted, recent re-examination of its remains and the elaborate inscriptional program led A. W. Najimi[13] to propose that the complex's southeast corner contained the tomb of Saif al-Din (r. 1161–1163) (Figure 4.5), 'Ala' al-Din *Jahan-suz*'s son. Saif al-Din was betrayed and treacherously assassinated in AH 558/1163 CE by his *sipahsalar* 'Abbas ibn Shish, who belonged to the long-time rival Shishani clan,[14] while the two were engaged in a military campaign preventing the Oghüz from traversing Gharjistan and threatening Ghur. Notably, Shah-i Mashhad's patron Jauhar Malik was not only the wife of Sultan Ghiyath al-Din, she was also the sister of Saif al-Din, so that brother and sister were Ghiyath al-Din's paternal cousins.[15]

Given the altered routes of communication throughout central Afghanistan in the modern day, both the Chisht and Gharjistan complexes – not to mention the seemingly enigmatic but pivotal site of Jam-Firuzkuh (cf. also Chapter 3) – have all received much less scholarly attention than they deserve. Moreover, the majority of recent and ongoing studies – including this one – have had to rely largely on archaeological and photographic documentation conducted decades earlier. Nevertheless, re-examination of the structures' architectural fabric, decorative iconography, and inscriptional programs provides invaluable insight into the coalescence of the Firuzkuh branch of the Shansabani confederacy, and the alacrity of this newly coalescing elite – despite their origins in the nomad–urban continuum – in joining the fray of architectural patronage to achieve political ends.

Until recently, both the Chisht and Gharjistan complexes appeared to have existed in splendid isolation, as monumental and heavily inscribed behemoths suddenly rising above expansive swaths of cultivated fields or mountainous landscapes, which were crossed here and there by throughways plied principally by nomads (Figure 4.4).[16] Such apparent isolation would undermine the substantial investment of labor and resources required in building what were originally large and rambling complexes; they appear to have been intended for habitation, just as their painstakingly planned and executed inscriptions were intended for reading, at least by the learned among their residents and passers-by.

In the early 2000s, the mapping and documentation of structural remains from Herat toward Chisht, extending eastward and flanking the Hari Rud, turned up residual traces of a very different historical landscape. To be sure, many remnants of fortified towers continue to be difficult to date, presenting problems not dissimilar to those in dating the structural remains in southern Ghur and west of Bamiyan (cf. Chapters 2 and 3). However, the formal characteristics and modes of construction of several other ruins along the Herat–Chisht routes indicate that these were either built – or perhaps already in use – during the period of Ghaznavid, Saljuq (late tenth–mid-twelfth centuries) and later political presences in